> after Charles Burnes was killed, and fire had consumed the whole of the room, Sir Alexander Burnes was obliged to come to the door opening to his garden. Here he implored the multitude to save his life, but [instead] receiving a torrent of abuse . . . abandoned all hopes of safety. On this he opened up his black neckcloth and tied it on his eyes, that he should not see from what direction the blow of death strikes him. Having done this, he stepped out of the door, and in one minute he was cut to pieces by the furious mob.[13]

‘The sharp blades of two hundred brave Afghans worked his body into shreds of bone,’ wrote Maulana Kashmiri.

> They strung them up for all to see
> From every corner flowed a river of blood.
>
> In booty they carried off all his wealth and goods
> As the autumn wind strips the leaves off a tree.[14]

Shortly after this, the rebels sent out a proclamation to the chiefs across the country: ‘On the third Tuesday of the blessed month Ramadan in the morning time, it occurred that with other heroic champions stirring like lions, we carried by storm the house of Sikander Burnes. By the Grace of the most holy and omnipotent God, the Brave Warriors having rushed right & left from their ambush, slew Sikander Burnes with various other Firangis of Consideration, and nearly 500 Battalion men, putting them utterly to the sword & consigning them to Perdition.’[15]

The trunk of Burnes’s headless body was left in the street to be eaten by the dogs of the city. For nearly a week, no one even thought to try and save anything of his mangled remains. Finally Burnes’s friend Naib Sharif, with whom he had spent many a lively evening, sent a servant to pick up the rotting remains and bury them in the garden of Burnes’s house.[16]

At the time of his death, Sir Alexander Burnes, soldier, spy, traveller, diplomat and thwarted deputy Envoy, was only thirty-six years old.

With Burnes’s house and Johnson’s treasury in flames, and the occupants of both houses slaughtered, the angry mob rippled out from the Sunni stronghold of Ashiqan wa Arifan and the Shor Bazaar, past Shah Zaman’s Pul-i-Khishti Masjid, and over the bridge in search of other targets. At the same time, as the news spread of plunder and profit, armed tribesmen began to pour into town from the rural hinterland. ‘The people of the surrounding region heard the news of Burnes’s assassination,’ wrote Fayz Mohammad.